

The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and the Treatment Gap

Data: Our World in Data / IHME, Global Burden of Disease (2025)

2023 Data

Hundreds of Millions Affected

1 in 3 Women and 1 in 5 Men Face Major Depression

1 in 3

Women

will experience major depression
in their lifetime

1 in 5

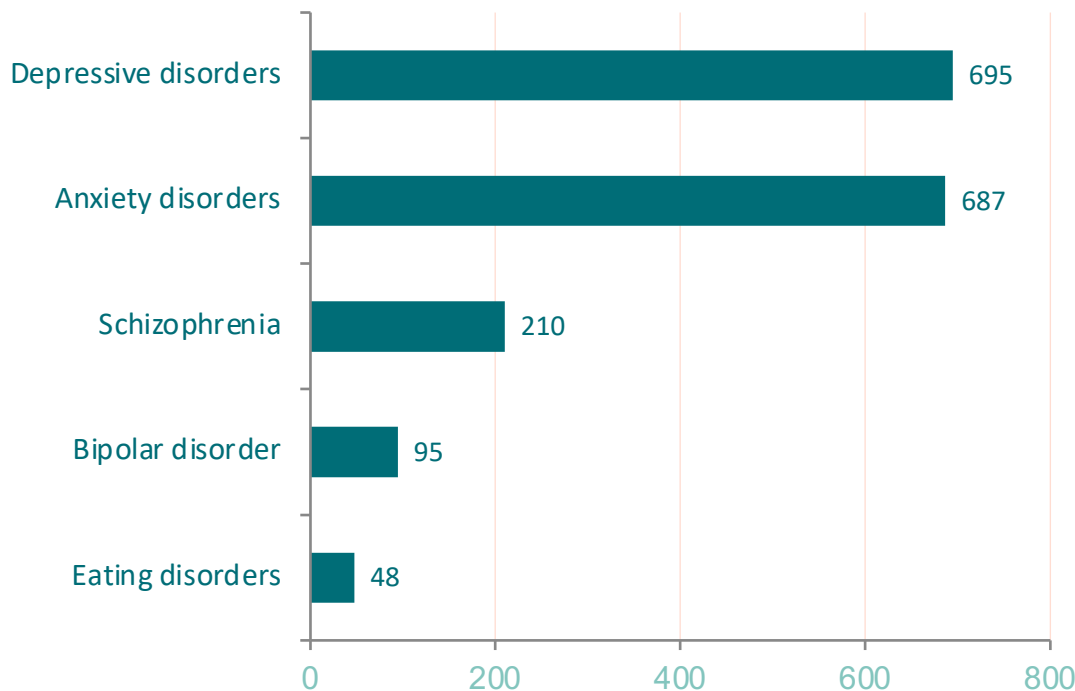
Men

will experience major depression
in their lifetime

Mental health conditions span from common (depression, anxiety) to less common but severe (schizophrenia, bipolar).
Understanding this scale is essential for effective policy.

Depression and Anxiety Dominate

~695 and ~687 DALYs per 100K Respectively



Key Insight

Depressive and anxiety disorders together account for roughly 80% of the total mental health disease burden across these five categories.

~80%

of mental health DALYs
from depression & anxiety

Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden Worldwide

694.6



Depressive Disorders

DALYs per 100,000

≈

686.5



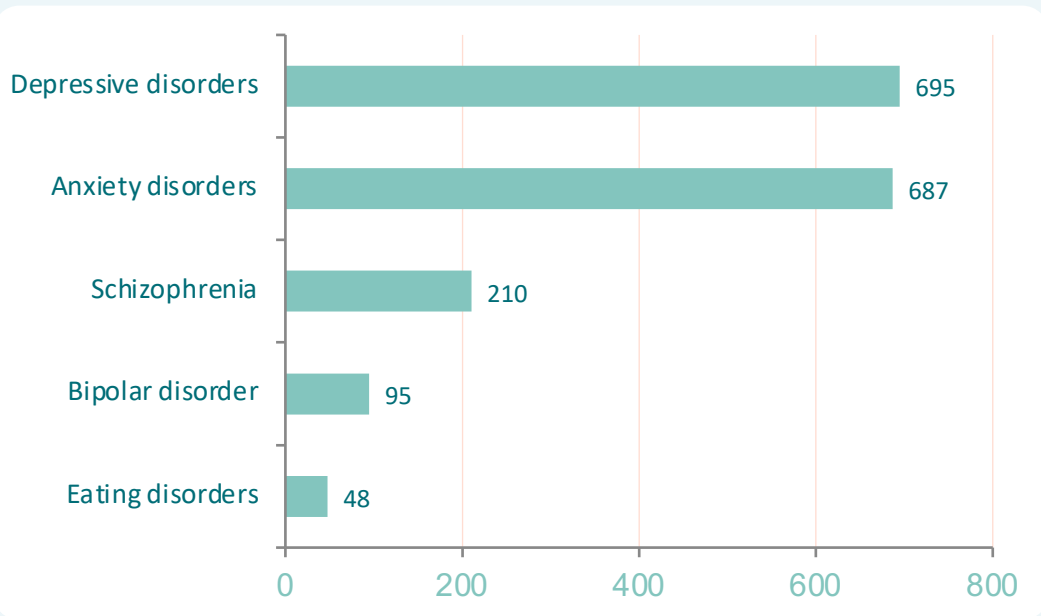
Anxiety Disorders

DALYs per 100,000

Together, depression and anxiety dwarf all other mental health categories in disease burden.

Schizophrenia and Bipolar Disorder

Lower Prevalence but Severe Individual Impact



210.2

Schizophrenia — DALYs per 100K

High individual disability despite
lower population prevalence

94.6

Bipolar Disorder — DALYs per 100K

Significant individual burden,
smaller population-level share

While population-level burden is lower, individual severity and disability are high — specialized care remains essential.

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality



Stigma

Many people are uncomfortable disclosing symptoms to healthcare professionals or people they know.



Access

Treatment is often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries.



Quality

Even where treatment exists, it may be of poor quality.



Underreporting

Discomfort with disclosure makes it difficult to estimate the true prevalence, meaning the actual burden may be higher

than reported.

Good data is essential to understand these conditions — how, when, and why they occur, and how they can be treated effectively.

How People Cope

From Medication to Faith to Family Conversations



Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings where healthcare infrastructure and access to pharmaceuticals are more readily available.



Religious & Spiritual Activities

Prevalent in many regions worldwide, reflecting cultural and faith-based approaches to managing mental health.



Talking to Friends & Family

A widely reported coping mechanism across countries, highlighting the role of social support in mental health.

Coping strategies vary widely across countries and cultures — policy must account for these differences, not apply a one-size-fits-all approach.

Key Takeaways

Prioritizing Depression, Anxiety, and Closing the Treatment Gap

- 1 Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs — each generating ~690 DALYs per 100,000.
- 2 Schizophrenia and bipolar carry disproportionate individual burden relative to their prevalence, requiring specialized care pathways.
- 3 Treatment exists but access and quality remain inadequate — the treatment gap is a central policy challenge.
- 4 Stigma suppresses both help-seeking and accurate data, meaning the true burden is likely underestimated.
- 5 Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common mental disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions.